ideas of the Twenty-Second Congress of the CPSU, to Marxism-Leninism—each, of course, in his own way," wrote the leading Soviet newspaper *Izvestiia* in December 1961. "Not even the American Federal Bureau of Investigation would venture to declare them all communists. If Fidel Castro proclaims himself a Marxist, Sukarno is not about to do so."[9]

As one could guess from the tone of the newspaper edited by his son-in-law, Nikita Khrushchev was anything but pleased by the self-outing of the alleged closet Marxist Castro. Privately Khrushchev welcomed the development but believed it premature on Castro's part to declare his socialist agenda and communist goals in public. He wrote in his memoirs: "We had trouble understanding the timing of that statement. Castro's declaration had the immediate effect of widening the gap between himself and the people who were against socialism, and it narrowed the circle of those he could count on for support against the invasion." He continued: "As far as Castro's personal courage was concerned, his position was admirable and correct. But from a tactical standpoint, it did not make much sense."[10]

If the statement made little tactical sense from Khrushchev's point of view, it made a great deal from Castro's. He needed weapons as soon as possible. By declaring his revolution socialist and himself a Marxist, he was putting Khrushchev on the spot: could the leader of the world communist movement say no to a Marxist leading a socialist revolution almost within sight of an imperialist monster? There was still no word from Moscow on the military assistance requested by Castro. On December 17, two weeks after his "I Am a Marxist" speech, Castro and his aides approached a man they believed to have a direct line to the Kremlin—the head of the KGB station in Cuba, Aleksandr Shitov, known to the outside world as Alekseev. The KGB man sensed the Cubans' unhappiness. They complained to him about unfulfilled promises on the part of Soviet officials to deliver missiles and warned of the "expected US aggression against Cuba." Alekseev filed a report to Moscow, but Khrushchev gave no response.[11]

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